

Trainers, Parasites, and Parasols

While both biplane and monoplane training aircraft introduced in this decade would for the most part be still serving faithfully over 50 years later—and some are still in active service rather than retired to leisure use—the 1930s also saw the final grand fling of the airships, vast lighter-than-air craft that in the end proved unable to withstand the full forces of nature and were retired after tragic crashes.



△ Bücker Bü131/CASA 1-131 1934

Origin Germany/Spain

Engine 150 hp Enma Tigre G-IV-B inverted air-cooled 4-cylinder in-line

Top speed 125 mph (201 km/h)

Originating in Germany but built in big numbers in Spain (about 530, including this one) and Japan (1,376), this tandem biplane was the primary trainer for the Luftwaffe and many other air forces worldwide.



△ de Havilland DH82 Tiger Moth 1931

Origin UK

Engine 130 hp de Havilland Gipsy Major I air-cooled inverted 4-cylinder in-line

Top speed 109 mph (175 km/h)

This highly successful tandem-seat dual-control trainer of which 8,868 were built, was used by the RAF and many other air forces. Still sometimes flown for training, it is now principally a leisure aircraft.

Hook for attaching aircraft to airship



◁ Curtiss F9C-2 Sparrowhawk 1931

Origin USA

Engine 415 hp Wright R-975-E3 air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 176 mph (283 km/h)

This was a "parasitic" aircraft operated from US Navy airships such as the USS Akron for reconnaissance and defense. There were up to four on an airship; they were deployed and recovered in midair.



△ Morane-Saulnier MS315 1932

Origin France

Engine 135 hp Salmons 9Nc air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 106 mph (171 km/h)

The MS315 was a primary-training parasol-wing monoplane of which 356 were built for the French air force and navy through WWII. In the 1960s, 40 were fitted with 220 hp Continental engines and renamed 317.

▷ Naval Aircraft Factory N3N-3 Canary 1935

Origin USA

Engine 235 hp Wright R-760-2 Whirlwind air-cooled 7-cylinder radial

Top speed 126 mph (203 km/h)

Designed and built (including license-built engines) by a factory wholly owned by the US government, the yellow Canary was in service with the US Navy as a primary trainer until 1961.



Age of the Airship

In the 1920s and 30s airships seemed a far more safe, luxurious, and reliable form of air travel than heavier-than-air craft. They could travel vast distances, smoothly and comfortably, with spacious passenger accommodation, and for war they made stable platforms for surveying the enemy. The US Navy developed airships with integral "hangars" that small aircraft could fly in and out of.

▽ USS Akron ZRS-4 1931

Origin USA

Engine 8 x Maybach VL2

Top speed 83 mph (134 km/h)

Built from 1929 with German help, the duralumin-framed Akron and its sister Macon were the largest ever helium-filled airships, each carrying four parasite aircraft. Akron crashed in severe weather in 1933.

